BOOKISHBAE

Everything We Didn't Say

A novel

Annu

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This is a work of fiction. Names, characters and incidents are the product of the author's imagination.

First edition.

June

The thing about Maya and Imran, his mother announced on the second evening, with the air of a woman delivering a diagnosis, is that you are both so well behaved.

Maya, who had spent the afternoon making three kinds of chutney specifically so that this conversation would not happen, said that she would take that as a compliment.

"Take it however you like," said Ammi, and helped herself to the chutney.

Imran said nothing, because he had spent eleven years establishing that saying nothing was the responsible option, and because his mother had just described his marriage more accurately in one sentence than he had managed in a decade.

July

The rain came in properly on the ninth and did not stop for six days, and the flat, which had always been exactly the right size for two polite people, revealed itself to be considerably smaller than that.

They discovered, in that week, that they disagreed about the window. About whether the window should be open two inches, as it had been every monsoon for eleven years, or closed, as Imran had apparently wanted every monsoon for eleven years without mentioning it.

"Why didn't you say?"

"Because it's a window, Maya."

"It's eleven years of a window."

Ammi, from the next room, said: now we are getting somewhere.

August

What they had, Maya decided somewhere around the middle of the month, was not a bad marriage. It was a well-maintained one. They had kept it the way you keep a car you are frightened of: regular servicing, nothing ambitious, never above fifty.

She told him this on the terrace, badly, with several false starts, and he listened with his jaw set in the way that had always meant he was hurt and had for eleven years been read as him being calm.

Then he said: "I thought you liked it like this." And she said: "I thought you did." And they sat with that for a while, in the particular silence of two people realising they have been exquisitely considerate of a person who does not exist.

Downstairs, Ammi had gone to bed early, on purpose, and was lying in the dark listening to the two of them finally raise their voices, and smiling at the ceiling.